

## TOPIC 7: PERSECUTION OF EARLY BELIEVERS (PART 1)

### 1. Arrest of Peter and John (Acts 3:1–11; 4:1–22)

Peter and John healed a lame man at the temple gate in the name of Jesus. As they spoke to the people, the priests and Sadducees arrested them. The next day they were questioned; Peter, filled with the Holy Spirit, proclaimed salvation in Jesus' name alone. The council charged them not to speak in that name; Peter and John answered that they must obey God rather than men. They were released and continued to speak the word with boldness.

### 2. Arrest and Martyrdom of Stephen (Acts 6:8–15; 7:1–60)

Stephen, full of grace and power, did great wonders. Opponents could not withstand his wisdom, so they brought false witnesses. Before the council Stephen reviewed Israel's history and charged them with resisting the Holy Spirit and killing the Righteous One. They were enraged, cast him out of the city and stoned him. Stephen prayed for his killers and died, the first Christian martyr. Saul approved of his execution.

### 3. Lessons

- Faithfulness may lead to opposition and suffering.
- Believers should obey God rather than human threats when the two conflict.
- Stephen's forgiveness models Christ-like love under persecution.

### 4. Summary

Peter and John faced arrest but spoke boldly; Stephen was martyred for his witness. Persecution did not stop the gospel.

End of Topic 7